



Palace of Versailles

A palace built to showcase the wealth and power of France's Sun King, Louis XIV

In the 1630s, King Louis XIII transformed a hunting lodge near the village of Versailles, outside Paris, into a modest château. His successor, Louis XIV, had ambitions on an altogether larger scale. In 1661, he ordered architect Louis le Vau to turn the building into a palace fit for an absolute monarch ruling by divine right, while the decoration of the interior was supervised by the artist Charles le Brun.

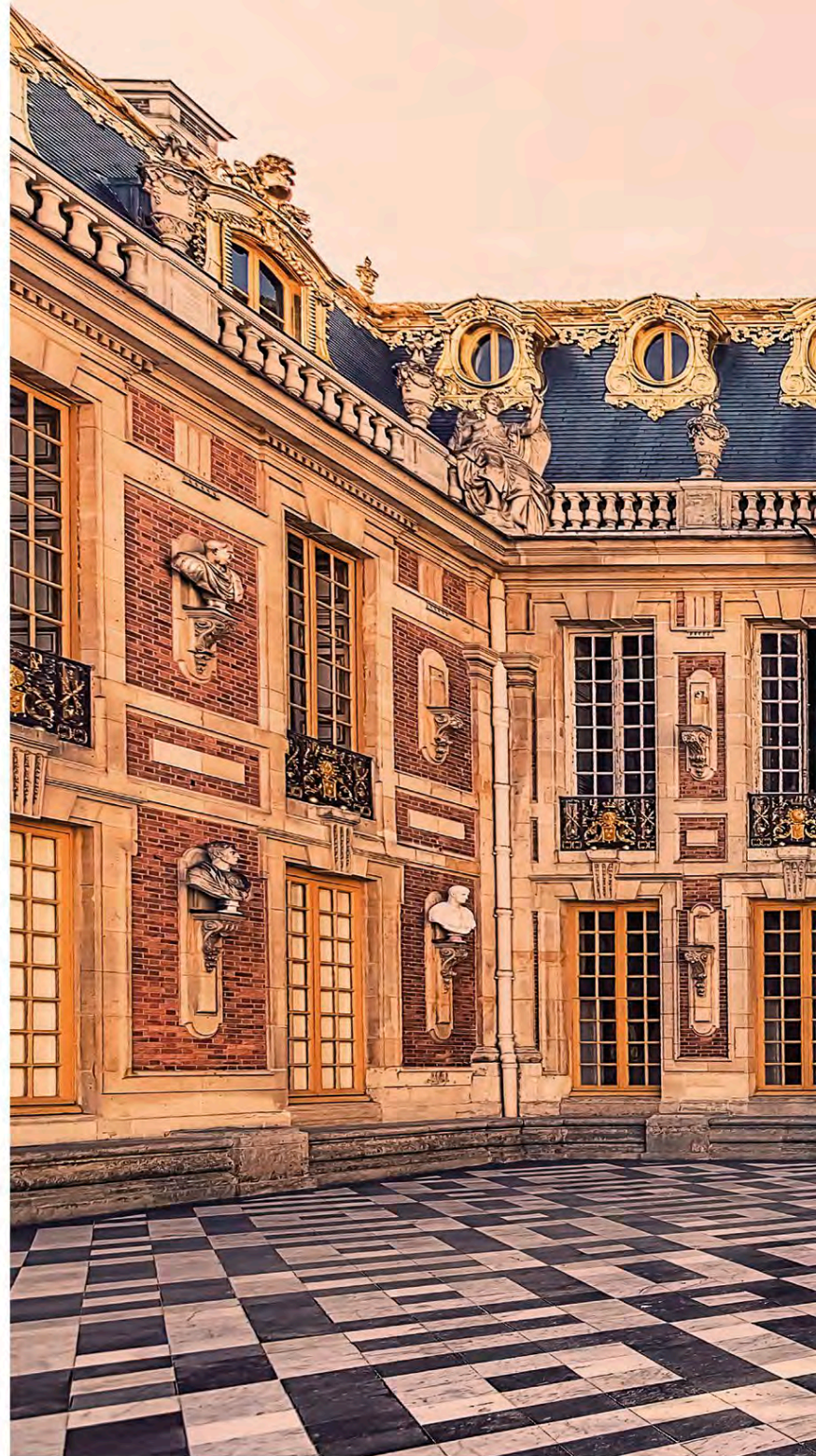
Courtly living

Louis XIV made Versailles the hub of his kingdom—the center of government and a place of court ritual where the French nobility were turned into slaves of etiquette. A new architect, Jules Hardouin-Mansart, added the splendid Hall of Mirrors, completed in 1684, as the palace continued to grow, its maze of corridors and staircases linking more than 700 rooms. Built in the grounds, the Grand Trianon—a small palace clad in pink marble—was a place of escape where the king could relax with his intimates. The Palace of Versailles served as a royal residence until the French Revolution of 1789 overthrew the monarchy. Today, it has a new vocation as one of the world's most visited tourist sites.



△ STATUE PARK

The gardens have more than 250 statues of mythological figures, many incorporated into spectacular fountains. Such statuary, with its Classical allusions, was an essential element of Baroque garden design.



△ WATER FEATURES

The palace has views across the formal gardens to the Grand Canal, where Louis XIV and his courtiers held elegant boating parties. Water pumped from the River Seine fed the fountains.



△ MARBLE COURT

The original château at Versailles, built for Louis XIII, still survives at the heart of Louis XIV's far grander palace. It surrounds a courtyard paved with black-and-white marble.

◁ HALL OF MIRRORS

Completed in 1684, the Hall of Mirrors is most famous as the site where the Treaty of Versailles was signed at the end of World War I. The hall contains 357 mirrors in total.